



The Philips READIUS has a rollable display that lets you carry around a much larger screen in a pocketable form factor

Philips READIUS

This is a really cool gadget! It features a rollable paper display in a device that can best be described as a “mobile e-reader.” The display is capable of four monochrome shades, that can be rolled up to a radius with a curvature as little as 7.5 mm. The contrast ratio displayed is 10:1 (bright to dark), more than sufficient to be able to read it in direct sunlight. The screen resolution is 320 x 240 (QVGA) pixels at a diameter of five inches. When closed, the device measures a mere 100 x 60 x 20 mm, obviously making it extremely pocket-able. We’re not quite sure about battery power, but reports say that the consumption is minimal.

Being a mobile gadget, it should be able to receive news and updates of various kinds (traffic, weather, and so on) quite easily, through Wi-Fi, WiMax, or even cellular networks. All this has still not been finalised, of course, but we’re hoping for the best!

This product is still a prototype, and its makers, Philips’ Polymer Vision, currently have no plans to mass-produce it—unless popular customer demands say otherwise. Basically, what this means is that they built this prototype to give us a glimpse of what’s possible, and should we decide that we just have to have one, some manufacturer or the other can lease the patent rights and provide us with products! A tall order indeed, but if you would like to support the “Build me a READIUS” cause, go to <http://www.polymervision.com/contact/Index.html> and demand that Polymer Vision start mass manufacturing some!

Everyday Life

Apart from the standard uses of paper displays in e-newspapers and e-readers, paper or rollable displays might have an important part to play in everyday life as well. The simplest example would be hoardings, where space can be sold as per the time of the day. So you could have animated advertisements that are just as visible in the day as in the night—current neon signs are useless in the day! There are also huge power savings that paper displays offer over neon signs. As for standard painted or printed billboards, they’re no competition to cheap paper display billboards that can be animated.

Apart from this, you could also see ultra-thin watches being made, which could be possible of displaying news or traffic updates at the push of a button.

Then there’s the whole print advertising industry to be thought of. Imagine if you got a copy of *Digit* that was just two pages thick, yet contained 10 times more content than it does currently! After all, all print magazines are limited to a certain number of pages due to printing and handling costs. But that’s still the content—what about the advertisements? Imagine if, instead of flipping pages, all you had to do was press a button, and as things are even now, there would be advertisements



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